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ENG 393

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Sonic Warning Reflection

A Sonic Warning: A Journey of Sound Creation

As I worked on creating the sonic warning, I followed the line of reflection in bringing both existing music and sound effects into this creation. For my background layer in this 30-second composition, I chose to use the song "Blue Darkness ~ A Sleepless Town" from the Texhnolyze OST. This song evokes feelings of uneasiness and tension, setting the tone for the warning. First, to immediately grasp one's attention upon listening, I started with the piercing wails of war sirens, simulating an emergency. After this, I layered in airstrike sirens and bomb sounds that increased the chaos and urgency in the scene. The reason I chose those sounds is because of the visceral reaction that it brings to people, in the hopes that through this method, listeners could resonate deep inside with a meaningful level of emotion. Immediately following the bomb sounds, I introduced the sound of rain as a means of symbolizing a cleansing effect to wash away the turmoil, therefore signifying transition toward peace. Rain is an auditory image of renewal, telling that even after devastation, healing can occur. I then added the chirping of birds and soft wind; both these sounds signify hope and recovery, how one returns back to normal and enjoys the beauty of life. I concluded the piece with upbeat music, followed by human laughter and chatter, having an environment of resilience and hope, all signals of an optimistic situation that starkly contrasts from the chaos at an earlier stage.

Five major decisions underpinned the production process for me, each mirroring my intended narrative through sound. First, there was the choice of track from the Texhnolyze OST, imperative in creating a dark and tragic mood to match this warning scenario that I tried to

portray. The haunting melodies and spooky harmonies of this track provided continuity and depth, placing the chaotic elements of war with an eerie calm. This duality is integral to storytelling because this is how the situation often happens in real life, where a balance between hope and despair goes hand in hand. I chose sirens and bomb sounds at the beginning because I wanted to achieve urgency or danger, which was the typical stance of a sonic warning to create immediate responses. The placement is strategic in setting the tone of the entire performance and ensuring that listeners are drawn into the narrative right from the very beginning. Third, this segues into the natural sounds of rain, followed by the songs of birds, to signal hope and recovery as a relief from the intense chaos. This shift not only serves as a moment of contemplation but also invites the audience to envision a world beyond conflict. Fourth, the addition of human voices, like laughter and chatter, helped convey a return to normalcy and tap into emotions dealing with rebuilding and moving on. This aspect of the composition humanizes life and reminds those listening that it goes on, and communities can heal. This balanced interplay between hopeful music and darker elements creates an emotional peak toward the end, which will highlight the themes of resilience, peace, and community. Balance is highly important here in order to provide a full emotional arc to the listener, from fear to hope, and reinforce the message of the composition.

With greater time and resources, I would develop my sonic warning in a number of ways to make it even deeper in impact. First, refinement of the quality of the sound through higher-quality samples, especially of bomb explosions and the siren, should provide realism for improving the whole immersive experience of the sound. The high-quality audio, therefore, will evoke more potent responses, visceral and engaging for the listener. I would further implement spatial audio effects to make the sound three-dimensional-like and possibly allow the sounds of

sirens to dynamically cross the audio soundscape. This would be achieved by placing the sound in diverse directions and making the warning more immediate, interactive, and charming, hence managing to simulate real life where one would actually feel surrounded by chaos. Thirdly, I would add more discreet background sounds-for example, murmurs of voices or ambient noise-to give the transitions of warning, destruction, and recovery a smoother feel that would come across as much more organic. These ambient sounds may allow for depth and realism in layers within the piece to create a rich tapestry of sound for capturing the listener's attention and imagination.

Integrating the ideas of scholars we studied this semester, particularly Gunther Kress, I realize that my sonic warning importantly deals with representation and communication. According to Kress, communication is a matter of conscious choice in representation, and here, the layering of sound elements-from the urgency of sirens to the soothing sounds of nature-represents a narrative of destruction and recovery. This also corroborates with the idea that different modes of communication shape how we experience things and fill them with meaning. I hence have chosen and placed these sounds carefully so as to not only convey warning but strong emotional journeys from human resilience to the response of adversity. The choices of the sounds and their treatment are neither solely technical nor a story that has engaged the listener on multi-levels. It is with this piece of work that I hope to show the strong impact that sound can have in shaping up narratives, eliciting emotions, and leading one to deeper insights of the human experience.